NO. 02
2021

TEMASEK HISTORY RESEARCH CENTRE

ISEAS YUSOF ISHAK INSTITUTE

DHARMAKĪRTI OF KEDAH: HIS LIFE, WORK AND TROUBLED TIMES

IAIN SINCLAIR

TEMASEK WORKING PAPER SERIES

The ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute (ISEAS) is an autonomous organization established in 1968. It is a regional centre dedicated to the study of socio-political, security, and economic trends and developments in Southeast Asia and its wider geostrategic and economic environment. The Institute's research programmes are grouped under Regional Economic Studies (RES), Regional Strategic and Political Studies (RSPS), and Regional Social and Cultural Studies (RSCS). The Institute is also home to the ASEAN Studies Centre (ASC), the Temasek History Research Centre (THRC) and the Singapore APEC Centre.

The Temasek Working Paper Series is an online publication series which provides an avenue for swift publication and wide dissemination of research conducted or presented within the Centre, and of studies engaging fields of enquiry of relevance to the Centre. The overall intent is to benefit communities of interest and augment ongoing and future research.

Iain Sinclair
Iain Sinclair (PhD, Monash University, 2016) is a lecturer at Nan Tien Institute, Australia, and an Honorary Research Fellow at The University of Queensland School of Historical and Philosophical Inquiry. He studies the Hindu-Buddhist culture of South Asia, the Himalayas and the Malay Archipelago. In 2018 and 2019 he was a Visiting Fellow at the Nalanda-Sriwijaya Centre (now THRC) of the ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute. His published research focuses on Buddhist tantra, medieval Asian history, Sanskrit manuscripts, classical art and contemporary religion.
Email: i_sinclair@outlook.com

Cover Image:
Standing buddha (often identified as Dīpaṃkara in late Buddhism) excavated from Jerai constituency, Kedah, by Dorothy Quaritch Wales in 1941. Bronze, 20.6 cm, 5th–9th century. Collection of the Asian Civilisations Museum, Singapore, Accession No. A-1354. Photograph: Iain Sinclair, 2019.

The Temasek Working Paper Series is published electronically by the Temasek History Research Centre of ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute.

© Copyright is held by the author/s of each Working Paper.

ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute accepts no responsibility for facts presented and views expressed. Responsibility rests exclusively with the individual author or authors. Authors have agreed that permission has been obtained from appropriate sources to include any content in the publication such as texts, images, maps, tables, charts, graphs, illustrations, and photos that are not exclusively owned or copyrighted by the authors. Authors have also agreed that proper referencing, acknowledgment and accreditation has been exercised according to professional standards.

The Temasek Working Paper Series cannot be republished, reprinted, or reproduced in any format without the permission of the paper's author/s.

Editors:
Helene Njoto
Andrea Acri

Assistant Editors:
Geoffrey Kevin Pakiam
Fong Sok Eng

Editorial Committee:
Terence Chong
Kwa Chong Guan
Helene Njoto

Temasek History Research Centre
ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute
30 Heng Mui Keng Terrace,
Singapore 119614
Tel: (+65) 6778 0955
Fax: (+65) 6775 6264

Website:
www.iseas.edu.sg/centres/thrc

Email:
thrc@iseas.edu.sg

Facebook:
www.fb.com/TemasekHistoryResearchCentre

ISSN: 2705084X

Dharmakīrti of Kedah: His Life, Work and Troubled Times

Iain Sinclair

abstract

One of the most influential figures of precolonial Southeast Asia was the monk known as Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles. In the early 11th century ce, the famous Atiśa, "Dīpaṃkara" (986–1054), sailed across the Bay of Bengal to study with him. Today this Dharmakīrti is remembered as the forefather of a religious tradition that was brought to Tibet by his illustrious student. However, few attempts have been made to locate his life and work in his nominal homeland. Little is known about what he taught, his exact whereabouts, or why Atiśa searched for him across the seas. This paper looks into and beyond Tibetan hagiography to examine potential traces of the Golden Isles Dharmakīrti in the Malay Peninsula, South India and China, as well as in the vast literature of late Buddhism. Accordingly, the authorship of 10th- and 11th-century works attributed to figures called Dharmakīrti will be investigated here, including the Āryācalasādhana, Vajrasūcī *and* Rūpāvatāra. *Secondary studies routinely state that the Golden Isles Dharmakīrti lived in Sumatra, but the only part of the region that is definitely linked to him is Lembah Bujang in Kedah. It has already been established that a king of Kedah, Cūḍāmaṇivarman (r. 1003–05), sponsored the major work of the Golden Isles Dharmakīrti, the* Durbodhālokā. *Here it will be shown that Kedah's location is also consistent with the itinerary of Atiśa's hazardous ocean voyage, and with information in an illuminated manuscript created in 1015 with unusual knowledge of the region. Tradition states that South Asian students were drawn to the Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles by his reputation; however, they clearly also sought to travel to the Golden Isles at a time when Buddhism on the subcontinent was starting to be engulfed in chaos.*

A troubled time is a spiritual guide,
evil spirits are buddhas multiplied,
illness is a broom for bad karma,
suffering is the play of things-as-they-are.

Suvarṇadvīpīya Dharmakīrti to Atiśa,
Mtha' 'khob 'dul ba'i chos bzhi 3

introduction

At the beginning of the second millennium ce, the Malay Archipelago was part of a broad transnational network linked by trade and religion. The region was increasingly known within this network as the 'Golden Isles', Suvarṇadvīpa. Since the mid-7th century the port cities across this region had been organised into the loose maritime confederation of Śrīvijaya. Although the ancestral home of the Śrīvijayans lay in Palembang, on the island of Sumatra, by the 10th century it was Kedah, on the Malay Peninsula, that

was Śrīvijaya's foremost settlement. e preeminence of Kedah at this time is apparent from its dealings with the Cōḻas of South India and the Song dynasty court, for whom Kedah and Śrīvijaya were becoming synonymous. Buddhists played a major role in these exchanges. It would be natural for the famed Buddhist guru of the Golden Isles to have been based primarily in Kedah. He was called Dharmakīrti, but as he was not the rst Buddhist thinker to use this name, he will be identi ed here as 'Dharmakīrti II'. If we can ascertain Dharmakīrti II's place in the region more precisely, we are better equipped to interpret a critical phase in the fortunes of his homeland, and to better explain why the region emerged at this time as a magnet for the Buddhist elite of northeastern India.

e aim of this paper is to appraise the textual evidence for Dharmakīrti II's life so that it can be brought into conversation with other forms of knowledge about the Maritime Southeast Asian region. Such bridges between the ndings of di erent disciplines can only be founded on solid understandings of the primary sources in their original languages. At the same time, texts that are remote in time and place from their subject matter and from us, as is the case with the sources for Dharmakīrti II, abound in uncertainty and non nality. It must also be emphasised that we are dealing with a badly fragmented milieu, in which the literate self-understandings of past eras are barely perceptible in the remains found on the ground today. e ndings of the present paper are o ered with these caveats. While attention is drawn to potentially interesting archaeological discoveries, this paper is not concerned with archaeology as such, but rather with supplying the classical contexts that need to inform such discoveries.

1. the life of the golden isles dharmakīrti

Most of what has been written about the life of Dharmakīrti II goes back to two Tibetan sources. Both provide detailed accounts of religious life in Southeast Asia at the beginning of the second millennium, yet they have hardly been noticed by historians of the region. Conversely, the Tibetologists who are familiar with their contents have refrained, with few exceptions, from following up what they say about Southeast Asia. ere is, rstly, the *Rnam thar rgyas pa*, in which the expression *rnam thar*, 'liberation', designates a spiritual journey. e title has been freely translated as *e Extensive Life-Story*. is is a biography of Dharmakīrti II's student Atiśa, who is also called Dīpaṃkara, Dīpaṃkaraśrījñāna and Jo bo rje in Tibet. *e Extensive Life-Story* provides a detailed narrative of Atiśa's life. It dates to the 13th century, but there are indications that it was pieced together from older sources going back to the late 11th century. It has been edited and summarised in German (Eimer 1977) and is known mainly to specialists in Tibetan Buddhism.

Secondly, there is a record of Atiśa's reminiscences from his sojourn in the region, as written down by his Tibetan student 'Brom ston pa (c. 1005–1064). Its title is *e Life-Story of His Eminence Meeting the Peerless Golden Isles Dharmakīrti* (*Jo bo rjes mnyam med Gser gling pa Chos kyi grags pa dang mjal ba'i rnam thar*). e rst half of the narrative relates Atiśa's troubled ocean passage to the Golden Isles, and the second concerns his arrival and meeting with Dharmakīrti II. It purports to be an eyewitness account, and it must be, to some extent, as it gives information on places, people and maritime technology that its redactor 'Brom ston pa—who was con ned to the Tibetan plateau—could not have either invented or sourced elsewhere. On the other hand, as there is internal evidence that the narrative was embroidered for local tastes (see Section 4.1), as well as the presence of agrantly supernatural elements, it can only be treated with cau-

tion as a historical source. It has been published several times (e.g., Jo bo 2010: 27–41), fully translated into English twice (ubten Kalsang 1974: 34–43; upten Jinpa 2006: 57–70) and quoted at length (Inandiak *et al*. 2018). A separate English translation of the rst part has also been published (Decleer 1995: 535–40). ese two texts— *e Extensive Life-Story* and *e Life-Story of His Eminence Meeting the Peerless Golden Isles Dharmakīrti*—are the main Tibetan accounts of the encounter between Dharmakīrti II and Atiśa (Fig. 1).

Fig. 1: ' e Incomparable Golden Isles Dharmakīrti' with palm trees (le); Atiśa in the Himalayas (right). From the frontispiece of a late blockprint (*Jo bo rje lha gcig dpal ldan A ti śas rgya gar du bstan pa ji ltar spel ba dang gser gling la phebs pa sogs kyi rnam thar*), MS shelfmark I.KERN 2740/H568a, Kern Institute, Leiden. <http://hdl.handle.net/1887.1/item:319806>

e early years of Dharmakīrti II are narrated in an excursus in *e Extensive Life-story*. Very little of this narrative can be tied to a particular place in Southeast Asia. Only a summary is given here, as a full translation based on a related textual tradition is freely available (Dás 1893: 8–9 n. ‡). A king of the Golden Isles, it is said, once had a young son who discovered a gilt statue of Śākyamuni in a cave. Inspired by this discovery, he travelled to Bodhgaya to seek a teacher and met the great master *Mahāśrīratna. is master le a week later, and the prince looked for him in the great places of pilgrimage: Lumbini, the Nairanjana river, and Benares. As the prince wondered whether to return to the Golden Isles, he heard two girls singing that land and property are nothing but a cause of su ering. He stayed in India, studied with various teachers for seven years and again had thoughts of giving up religion. During a ritual at Bodhgaya, an old woman spoke a verse on impermanence to him. en, while dreaming, he saw the great master again, and promised to devote himself to the Dharma. When he awoke, *Mahāśrīratna stood before him. e master instructed him on the rousing of the thought of enlightenment, *bodhicitta*, and on the altruistic writings of Śāntideva, the *Śikṣāsamuccaya* and *Bodhicaryāvatāra*. He gave the prince the name 'Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles' (Gser gling pa chos kyi grags pa, 'Serlingpa'). e prince returned to the Golden Isles, and 'the tenets of the non-Buddhists waned everywhere.' So says the traditional account of Dharmakīrti II's life up to the point where he became a guru of renown.

1.1. e Golden Isles Dharmakīrti's Name and Teacher

Dharmakīrti's teacher *Mahāśrīratna has not yet been located in the wider Buddhist world. *e Extensive Life-story* calls him a 'great master' (*slob dpon chen po*) and leaves the impression that he was well known, but he is only ever mentioned in connection with Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles. No independent information on him has come to light.

e rst problem is *Mahāśrīratna's name; it is doubtful that it conforms to a valid monastic naming convention, although little is known about such conventions. Monastic names pre xed with the word *mahat* are, in any case, rare. In *e Extensive Life-story*'s etymological analysis of the name *Mahāśrīratna, the *mahat* element is instead identi ed with the title *mahāpaṇḍita* or *mahāsattva* (Eimer 1977 II: 21). is points to an understanding that the *mahat* element was an abbreviation of another word.[1] Elsewhere in the text, the master's name is given in Tibetan simply as Rin chen dpal (Eimer 1977 II: 22), that is, as *Ratnaśrī. As such, the name *Mahāśrīratna appears to be a distorted back-Sanskritization of an expression such as Mahāpaṇḍita-Ratnaśrī.

An accomplished Sinhalese pundit called Ratnaśrījñāna (. 920s–70s) was well placed to have known Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles. is Ratnaśrī was a proli c writer of literary works in Sanskrit, and—as Dragomir Dimitrov has argued—in Pāli and Sinhala as well. Ratnaśrījñāna was active at Bodhgaya, where he composed an epigraph engraved in the year 944. His major work on Sanskrit poetics was completed in 952. He appears to have started writing in Sinhala, presumably back in Lanka, a few years later (Dimitrov 2016: 741). It has been ventured that Ratnaśrījñāna knew the *Bodhicaryāvatāra*; he used an expression that also occurs only in Prajñākaramati's commentary on the *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (Dimitrov 2016: 592 n. 66). He lived earlier than the persons called Ratnaśrī who are named in connection with late tantric texts translated into Tibetan (e.g. Derge 1239, 1715) in the 11th century. If the Golden Isles Dharmakīrti's teacher was the 10th-century Sinhalese monk, that would explain an otherwise ba ing statement in his *Life-Story*. eir meeting at Bodhgaya is related as follows:

> At the time he arrived there the Rākṣasas (probably the Simhalese) had also come to reverence the Mahābodhi. ere also simultaneously congregated all the learned and talented men of the Buddhist world. e great *ācārya* Mahā Śrī Ratna, who had acquired the power of attaining to extraordinary longevity, was also present on the occasion. (Chimpa and Chattopadhyaya 1967: 86)

As the translators of this passage realised—here Chimpa and Chattopadhyaya follow the wording of Dás—the word **rākṣasa*, 'cannibal, ghoul' (*srin po*), refers to inhabitants of Sri Lanka. e context, Bodhgaya, indicates that these *rākṣasa*s must be monks, that is, hardline Sinhalese monks. e narrator thereby sets the scene for a meeting between an unusually friendly Sinhalese pundit and a princeling from Southeast Asia. If the young prince had encountered the Sinhalese Ratnaśrī during his sojourn at Bodhgaya, during the mid-940s to the mid-950s, his approximate age can be determined; Dharmakīrti would then have been born no later than about 930–40.

e hagiographic literature does not say why the prince from the Golden Isles received the name Dharmakīrti. is is a question of some interest, as Dharmakīrti the

1 For another attempt to get sense out of the Tibetan here see Seton (2015: 50–1).

logician was certainly well known in this milieu. e Sinhalese Ratnaśrī quoted the logician Dharmakīrti by name (akur 1957: 58). Furthermore, Dharmakīrti the logician is quoted by Dharmakīrti II himself; some references are given below in connection with the *Durbodhālokā* (Section 3.1). Yet the Golden Isles guru simply called himself 'Dharmakīrti' without quali cation. is is now clearly seen from a manuscript of his *Durbodhālokā* preserved in the original Sanskrit (Sferra 2008: 51, 3.2.14), which will be discussed further in Section 3.1. However, the secondary literature—going back to Obermiller (1933: 11) and continuing up to the present (Skilling 1992: 191; Seton 2015)—has used the arti cial name *Dharmakīrtiśrī. is name was reconstructed from Tibetan sources and is not known to be attested in Sanskrit. e manuscript tradition of the *Durbodhālokā* shows that *Dharmakīrtiśrī is a misnomer.

e original wording of the appellation 'of the Golden Isles', Tibetan Gser gling pa—also written Serlingpa—can now be recovered with the help of a recently discovered document. A codex containing a Sanskrit work by one 'Suvarṇadvīpīya Sugataśrīmitra' has come to light in the Tibet Autonomous Region of China (Matsuda 2019: 25). Nothing is known about this Sugataśrīmitra at present, but his a liation to the Golden Isles di erentiates him from the late 11th-century Kashmirian called Sugataśrīmitra, who collaborated on the Tibetan translation of a *Nāmasaṃgīti* commentary (Derge 1396). e Sanskritic name of Atiśa's famous teacher can then be rightly restored—if it had ever been written in Sanskrit—as Suvarṇadvīpīya Dharmakīrti.

1.2. e Students of Dharmakīrti II

e top students of the Golden Isles Dharmakīrti are named in *e Extensive Life-Story* (Eimer 1977 II: 40; Seton 2015: 40). He is said to have had four students from the subcontinent who became great pundits: Śāntipā, that is, Ratnākaraśānti (. c. 970–1045); Atiśa himself; and Jñānaśrīmitra and Ratnakīrti (both . late 10–early 11th c.). Whereas the former two of his students wrote on a range of topics in Buddhism, the latter two are known primarily as logicians. e association between these four gures—who are all said to have resided at Vikramaśīla monastery—can be independently con rmed insofar as their works form a coherent 'intellectual sequence' (Katsumi 1992). Ratnākaraśānti, however, is believed to have remained in Eastern India during Atiśa's sojourn in the Golden Isles (Seton 2015: 42). It is therefore supposed that Dharmakīrti II taught at Vikramaśīla, Ratnākaraśānti's monastery, and that Atiśa rst met Dharmakīrti II on the Subcontinent (Eimer 1981: 74).

e four students disagreed on certain doctrinal questions (Seton 2015: 39–42). Ratnākaraśānti and Atiśa, especially, seem to have sparred intellectually over a long period. A verse penned by Ratnakīrti can be read as alluding to this fraternal rivalry. At the start of his *Īśvarasādhanadūṣaṇa*, Ratnakīrti states: 'I write to remember, having taken out something from the word-sea of the guru' (*guror vāgambudheḥ smartuṃ kiñcid ākṛṣya likhyate*), which, 'resting on pearls of wisdom' (*sūktaratnāśrayatvena*), 'produced the defeat of the ocean and more' (*jitaratnākarādidam*).[2] Here the 'ocean', literally the 'jewel-yielder' (*ratnākara*)—that is, a site of pearling and coral harvesting—means the ocean of *saṃsāra*, the cycle of rebirth. At the same time, Ratnakīrti may well have in mind the one whose 'word-sea … defeated Ratnākara(śānti)', namely, Atiśa. e expression *ji-*

2 For the Sanskrit text of this verse, see Patil (2001: 307).

taratnākara may further allude to Atiśa's triumphant voyage to the Golden Isles. Ratnakīrti would then have provided a rare non-Tibetan reference to this de ning moment of Atiśa's career.

1.3. Late Dharmakīrtis in Non-Tibetan Sources

References to persons called Dharmakīrti or equivalent names, who can be clearly di erentiated from Dharmakīrti the logician, appear in various Asian writings from the 10th century onwards. e rst one to emerge in Southeast Asia, known as Kīrtipaṇḍita, lived too early to be identi ed with the guru of the Golden Isles.[3]

One Dharmakīrti visited the court of the Northern Song dynasty. In 1001, two 'South Indian monks' called *Dharmakīrti (Facheng) and *Buddhacandra (Foyue) came to the court bearing gi s. *Dharmakīrti presented eight Sanskrit manuscripts and a bodhi-tree seed rosary (*puti zi*), while *Buddhacandra presented one Sanskrit manuscript and minor religious items, according to the *Da zhong xian fu Fa bao lu* (Takeuchi 1976: 30). Was this the Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles? e assignment of the two monks to 'South India', according to the convention of Chinese record-keeping, would normally indicate place of origin, but it could have the narrower sense of port of departure. e Kedah court had frequent dealings with the South Indian Cōḻa dynasty at the time of King Rājarāja I (r. c. 985–1014), which culminated in the founding of the royal Cūḍāmaṇivihāra in the port of Nagapattinam in 1006. Dharmakīrti II must have known about this monastery, and could well have participated in inaugurating it, as it was dedicated to his patron, King Cūḍāmaṇivarman.

e Dharmakīrti who reached Song China was then travelling at a time of intensive high-level religious contact between the Kedahan, Cōḻar and Northern Song dynastic establishments. If it was the Dharmakīrti of the Golden Isles who had been in China in 1001, he would have been in a position to lay the groundwork for another grand act of transnational religiosity two years later. In 1003, at Cūḍāmaṇivarman's request, Emperor Zhenzong named and donated a bell for a monastery in Śrīvijaya. He gave it the name Chengtianwanshou (equivalent to *Prāptadivyasahasrāyuṣa in Sanskrit or Pendeh Swarga Dirgahayu in Malay). Alternatively, if the 'South Indian' origin of this Dharmakīrti is taken wholly at face value, he is then a candidate for identi cation with Dharmakīrti the grammarian, whose works and possible connection with Dharmakīrti II are discussed in Section 3.5.

Another Dharmakīrti is referred to as a yogic master whose students who become adepts (*siddha*), as narrated in the *Kings' Prophecy* (*Rājavyākaraṇa*) chapter 53 of the *Mahākālatantra*. is chapter tells of events and personalities that emerge across the Buddhist world in a prophetic future, but which were already well in the past when the *Mahākālatantra* became known to Tibetans in the late 11th century. What exactly the *Kings' Prophecy* says about Dharmakīrti is not yet clear, as the passage in question has been transmitted in unedited Sanskrit manuscripts that are riddled with textual problems (the *Mahākālatantra* manuscripts kept at the Bibliothèque nationale de France, the University of Tokyo, and the Asha Archives in Kathmandu were consulted for this paper).

3 Kīrtipaṇḍita, a foreign Buddhist master at the Khmer court, whose life is brie y recounted in the Wat Sithor inscription of Jayavarman V (968–1001), has been speculatively linked to Dharmakīrti II (Seton 2015: 43). He predates Dharmakīrti II by at least a generation tnd cannot be connected with the Malay world.

e Tibetan translation, as quoted by the Tibetan historian Bu ston (Obermiller 1932: 120), represents just one snapshot of a problematic textual tradition, and cannot yet be taken to represent a de nitive understanding of the *Kings' Prophecy* chapter. More work on this is needed.

2. the golden isles, kedah and dharmakīrti's place of residence

e part of the Golden Isles where Dharmakīrti II completed his major work, the *Durbodhālokā*, is identi ed with clarity in the Tibetan translation of this work. It is Kedah.

e colophon of the translation names Dharmakīrti's patron as *Śrī-Cūḍāmaṇivarmadeva (Lha dpal gtsug gi nor bu'i go cha') of *Suvarṇadvīpa (Gser gling) and its place of composition as *Śrīvijayapura (Dpal rnam par rgyal ba'i grong). is Cūḍāmaṇivarman is well known from the Chinese *Song shi* 宋史 as the ruler of Śrīvijaya, and from Tamil charters, speci cally, as ruler of Kaḍāram, i.e. Kedah. ese are all 'contemporary and reliable documents', as was observed in the rst published analysis of the *Durbodhālokā*'s Tibetan colophon (Skilling 1992: 191). However, it is not quite the case that 'it cannot be said' whether Kedah is 'in modern Malaysia or Siam' (*ibid*.). Classical Kedah is generally agreed to have been located in the Lembah Bujang–Sungai Merbok area (Fig. 2), which today lies at the heart of the Malaysian state of Kedah. Lembah Bujang, once the site of a major Hindu-Buddhist civilization, is an archaeological site of unique importance in the Malay Peninsula. Excavations carried out since the late 1930s, most recently by local teams, have uncovered more than y sites dated from between the 3rd and 14th centuries (Rosli *et al*. 2020: 1311 g. 1). e cultural and religious dimensions of the civilization uncovered in Kedah have not, however, been at all fully explored or understood (Murphy 2017).

Fig. 2: Aerial view of Lembah Bujang, Kedah, Malaysia, showing Gunung Jerai (right), Sungai Merbok estuary (centre), and Penang (upper le). Photograph: Maru sh, 'Birdview of Gunung Jerai', <https://www. ickr.com/photos/maru sh/30101425702/in/photostream/> detail with applied colour correction, CC BY-SA 2.0